The New Colossus, The Newer Colossus and Immigrants in Our Own Land

By Emma Lazarus, Karen Finneyfrock and Jimmy Santiago Baca

The New Colossus by Emma Lazarus

Not like the brazen giant of Greek fame,

With conquering limbs astride from land to land;

Here at our sea-washed, sunset gates shall stand

A mighty woman with a torch, whose flame

Is the imprisoned lightning, and her name Mother of

Exiles.

From her beacon-hand

Glows world-wide welcome; her mild eyes command

The air-bridged harbor that twin cities frame.

"Keep, ancient lands, your storied pomp!" cries she

With silent lips. "Give me your tired, your poor,

Your huddled masses yearning to breathe free,

The wretched refuse of your teeming shore.

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Send these, the homeless, tempest-tost to me,

I lift my lamp beside the golden door!"

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Emma Lazarus
Book: The Poems of Emma Lazarus, Volume II
ISBN: 978-0486786438
Publisher: Dover Publications
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2015

INTRODUCTION

Between 1820 and 1920, approximately 34 million persons immigrated to the United States, three-fourths of them staying permanently. For many of these newcomers, their first glimpse of America was the Statue of Liberty in New York harbor.

The Jewish American poet Emma Lazarus saw the statue as a beacon to the world. The poem you just heard (The New Colossus) is carved on that pedestal, and at the time captured what the statue had come to mean to the millions who migrated to the United States seeking freedom.

But times change and so do societies . . . . It is now over 100 years from the date that the Statue of Liberty was opened on October 28, 1886 and Karen Finnefrock has revisited the theme of immigration from the viewpoint of Lady Liberty in her poem The Newer Colossus.

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The Newer Colossus by Karen Finnefrock

My feet have been wilting in this salt-crusted cement
since the French sent me over on a steamer in pieces.
I am the new Colossus, wonder of the modern world,
a woman standing watch at the gate of power.

The first night I stood here, looking out over the
Atlantic
like a marooned sailor, plaster fell from my lips parting
and I said, Give me your tired, your poor, like a woman
would say it, full of trembling mercy, while the rats ran
over my sandals and up my stairwell, I was young then
and hopeful.

I didn't know who Europe and Asia, eventually the Middle
East, would keep pushing their wretched through the
bay like
a high tide. I am choking on the words I said about
the huddled masses, they huddle on rafts leaving Cuba
and we

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turn them back. They huddle in sweltering truck backs
crossing
the desert and we arrest them. I heard about a
container
ship where three Chinese hopefuls died from lack of
oxygen
pretending to be dishrags for our dollar stores. How can
we not
have room for them? We still have room for golf
courses.

I am America's first liar, forget about George
Washington.
My hypocrisy makes me want to plant my dead face in
the
waves. The ocean reeks of fish and tourism, my optimist
heart
corrodes in the salt wind.

Give me your merchandise, I should say.

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Give me your coffee beans. Give me your bananas and avocados, give me your rice. We turn our farmland into strip malls, give me things to sell at my strip malls. Give me your Ethnic cuisine, your cheaply made plastics, give me, by trembling boatload, your Japanese cars. Give me your oil.

Not so I can light my lamp with it, but to drool it from the thirsty lips of my lawn mowers. Give me your jealousy, your yearning to crawl inside my hollow bones and sleep in my skin made of copper. Look,

over there is New York. Doesn't it glow like the cherry end of a cigarette? Like a Nebula from the blackness of space out here in the harbor? Wait with me. Watch it pulse like a hungry lion until morning. I should tell you to enjoy it from here. You will never be allowed to come in.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Karen Finneyfrock
Book: We Will be Shelter
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Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
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TRANSITION

No matter what your politics on the issue of immigration are, it is important to remember that all immigrants come to America with our own hopes and dreams, but too often we face inevitable disappointment instead. We're not always who you think we are. Some pick your strawberries or care for your children. Some are in high school or college. And many sit in jail cells awaiting deportation.

Me? I grew up here. This is my home. Yet even though I think of myself as an American and consider America my country, my country doesn't think of me as one of its own. Immigrants in Our Own Land by Jimmy Santiago Baca.

Immigrants in Our Own Land
by Jimmy Santiago Baca

We are born with dreams in our hearts,

looking for better days ahead.

At the gates we are given new papers,

our old clothes are taken
and we are given overalls like mechanics wear.
We are given shots and doctors ask questions.
Then we gather in another room
where counselors orient us to the new land
we will now live in. We take tests.
Some of us were craftsmen in the old world,
good with our hands and proud of our work.
Others were good with their heads.
They used common sense like scholars
use glasses and books to reach the world.
But most of us didn't finish high school.

The old men who have lived here stare at us,
from deep disturbed eyes, sulking, retreated.
We pass them as they stand around idle,
leaning on shovels and rakes or against walls.
Our expectations are high: in the old world,
they talked about rehabilitation,
about being able to finish school,
and learning an extra good trade.

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But right away we are sent to work as dishwashers,
to work in fields for three cents an hour.
The administration says this is temporary
So we go about our business, blacks with blacks,
poor whites with poor whites,
chicanos and indians by themselves.
The administration says this is right,
no mixing of cultures, let them stay apart,
like in the old neighborhoods we came from.

We came here to get away from false promises,
from dictators in our neighborhoods,
who wore blue suits and broke our doors down
when they wanted, arrested us when they felt like,
swinging clubs and shooting guns as they pleased.
But it's no different here. It's all concentrated.
The doctors don't care, our bodies decay,
our minds deteriorate, we learn nothing of value.
Our lives don't get better, we go down quick.

My cell is crisscrossed with laundry lines,

my T-shirts, boxer shorts, socks and pants are drying.
Just like it used to be in my neighborhood:
from all the tenements laundry hung window to window.
Across the way Joey is sticking his hands
through the bars to hand Felipé a cigarette,
men are hollering back and forth cell to cell,
saying their sinks don't work,
or somebody downstairs hollers angrily
about a toilet overflowing,
or that the heaters don't work.

I ask Coyote next door to shoot me over
a little more soap to finish my laundry.
I look down and see new immigrants coming in,
mattresses rolled up and on their shoulders,
new haircuts and brogan boots,
looking around, each with a dream in their heart,
thinking they'll get a chance to change their lives.

But in the end, some will just sit around
talking about how good the old world was.

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Some of the younger ones will become gangsters.
Some will die and others will go on living
without a soul, a future, or a reason to live.
Some will make it out of here with hate in their eyes,
but so very few make it out of here as human
as they came in, they leave wondering what good they are now
as they look at their hands so long away from their tools,
as they look at themselves, so long gone from their families,
so long gone from life itself, so many things have changed.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jimmy Santiago Baca
Book: Immigrants in Our Own Land & Selected Early Poems
ISBN: 978-0811211451
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Date (Month/Year): Nov 1990